ROLE PLAY: REQUIREMENTS ELICITATION (Dee Bank)

Case Scenario

Dee Bank is a fast-growing fintech in Nigeria expanding its online services to make merchant onboarding, payments, and settlement easier for SMEs. Currently, applications arrive through multiple channels like form, email, chat with no standard checklist. Merchants cannot easily see their status or settlement timeline. Support teams are overwhelmed by repeated enquiries, and internal teams use disjointed tools and inconsistent terminology. Management wants a clearer, faster, more transparent process with reliable settlement visibility.

My BA team has been asked to begin requirements elicitation before the solution is designed.

Role Play

This project will simulate a real BA elicitation session. The objective is to discover needs, pain points, constraints, expectations and unanswered questions.

Roles

Business Analyst (BA): Leads the session. Explains the purpose, asks open and closed questions, actively listens, probes unclear answers, takes notes and identifies follow up questions.

Finance & Reconciliation Team: Shares settlement timing, cut-offs, and describes current manual settlement and enquiry process.

Customer Support Team: Describes daily enquiries from merchants, explains where information is found and why answers sometimes differ, they shares what would most help their daily work.

Onboarding Operation Team: Explains how applications are received and processed, identifies where delays happen and what causes them, describes status language and handoffs between teams.

Merchants (End Users): Shares their experience applying, explains what information was missing or unclear, describes what they want to see on settlements and why it matters to their business.

Part 1: Preparation before the interview

Goal of this elicitation session: Is to uncover the real needs, pain points, missing information, and constraints in Dee Bank's merchant onboarding and settlement process. So we can design a solution that actually solves what people experience, not just what we assume is happening.

Participating Stakeholders: Merchants (End Users), Customer Support Team, Onboarding Operations Team, Product Managers, and Finance & Reconciliation Team.

Elicitation technique selected: Open ended questions to explore experiences, shadows/follow ups to gain more insights, and discussions to reveal conflicting views.

What information do we already know? Applications arrive through multiple channels with no standard process, no upfront document checklist, merchants cannot view status or settlement timelines, support teams receive repeated enquiries, internal teams use disjointed tools and inconsistent terminology.

What do we need to discover? Exact stage where documents most get missing, the real step-by-step process and where delays occur, settlement cut-off times, rules, and weekend/holiday processing, what visibility merchants actually want, what information can be

shared publicly versus must remain confidential, what can be automated versus requires manual review.

Part 2: Interview / Role Play

- How do merchants currently apply to become on boarded?
- What happens after someone submits the application (request that staff walk us through the steps)?
- How do we record or track application status?
- What are the most common problems or delays you see in the process?
- Can you describe the last time a merchant was confused about when settlement funds would arrive?
- How do you or the merchant know what stage an application is at?
- What happens when documents are missing or unclear and how does that affect timelines?
- How are settlement dates, cut-offs, and processing schedules communicated today?
- If merchants could check one thing themselves without messaging you, what would it be?
- Are there rules, compliance checks, or limits that we must never overlook?
- What part of the current process works well and what should we *not* change?
- What features would make you say the new system is working perfectly?

Part 3: Capture What You Hear

Stakeholder said / observed	**Need or pain point**	**Possible requirement**	**Follow-up question**
They apply via multiple channels	Application duplication,	One unified application	Can we phase out other channels once this is live?

	errors	portal as primary entry point	
No one tells them what to bring during onboarding	No pre-application checklist	Publish complete document list	what documents are missing most often?
Merchants are not aware that settlement cut off is Thursday noon an other transactions thereafter go to the following week	Unpublished settlement rules causes anxiety	Publish settlement schedule	Are cut-offs always the same time/day?
Half of the enquiries is about settlement funds	Customer support team are overloaded	Creation of Merchant dashboard	What is the very first thing they should see?

Part 4: Conflicting Stakeholder Needs

Merchants and the Customer support Team want full, instant visibility of settlement dates, fee breakdowns, and fund hold reasons on a public dashboard, while Finance and Compliance team state that some settlement details are confidential and restricted so they cannot be shown openly due to data protection regulations. Only general, pre-approved settlement information can be displayed publicly, sensitive details reviewed and approved before sharing on dashboards as all regulatory and confidentiality rules must be strictly followed.

What evidence do we need?

A written list from Compliance confirming exactly what settlement details can be published versus what must remain private, confirmation from Finance on which data fields in the settlement system are safe to display publicly.

How should the BA handle the conflict?

Bring both groups together to agree what information is safe to show first, start with clear estimated dates and timelines, add more detailed information only once Compliance has approved it, document every decision clearly so everyone works from the same agreed version.

Part 5: After the Interview

Key findings:

- Merchants apply through multiple channels. This causes work duplication and confusion.
- No document checklist is shared upfront, applications arrive incomplete and this leads to delay from day one.
- Merchants get anxious and worried as Settlement cut-offs, schedules, and rules exist internally but are never published to them.
- Teams use different status words "in review" means different things to different people in the team while merchants get conflicting answers.
- Self-service status and settlement visibility is the top request from both merchants and support staff.

Functional needs identified:

- To use unified merchant application form as one standard entry point.
- Real-time status tracking to be shared across all teams.

- Automated email/SMS notifications will be sent at each stage change.
- Public settlement schedule showing cut-offs, processing days, and estimated timelines.
- Merchant dashboard will be created for 24/7 self-service updates.

User needs identified:

- Merchants want clarity, predictability, and less cash flow anxiety.
- Merchants also want consistent answers and fewer repeated enquiries
- Operations want a standardised process with no re-typing of information
- Finance wants accurate data and controlled information disclosure
- Compliance wants regulatory rules followed and no sensitive details over-shared on staff dashboard.

Pain points identified:

- No upfront checklist, incomplete applications, avoidable delays.
- No single source of truth, conflicting replies from staff.
- No self-service, customer support team is overwhelmed with repetitive applications
- No published settlement rules, uncertainty and probable anxiety stress for merchant businesses.
- Slow or no handoffs between teams.

Constraints / risks identified:

- Regulatory limits restrict what settlement details can be shown publicly on the dashboards.
- Staff members need trainings to migrate from spreadsheets to a central digital platform.
- Merchants need to be encouraged to adopt the new channels.

Questions for the parking lot:

- What is the official service level agreement (SLA) for application reviews and fund settlement?
- Do weekends and public holidays add 1 day or 2days to settlement timelines?

Part 6 Validate and Confirm:

Summary to stakeholders: From our discussion, our understanding is that Dee Bank needs a standardized onboarding process, with clear requirements shared upfront, one shared status system visible to merchants, and transparent settlement timelines approved by Finance and Compliance. We also understood that inconsistent processes, manual tracking, and unpublished information are the root causes and that giving merchants visibility will help customer support teams as well. We still need clarification on exactly which settlement details can be shown publicly, how weekend processing shifts timelines, and whether requirements differ by merchant size or type.

Stakeholder confirmation/correction:

All stakeholders agreed with the summary, finance team would draft the public settlement schedule for Compliance review. Operations confirmed document requirements are mostly the same for all SME merchants, weekend processing timelines to be finalized by Finance.

Part 7: BA Reflection

Which question produced the most useful information?

If you could change just one thing to make your work or experience better, what would it be?

It surfaced the real daily frustrations that formal complaints didn't always capture, and revealed that self service visibility is the shared priority across everyone.

What assumption did you discover was wrong or incomplete?

I assumed delays were mostly caused by slow system processing, but the real bottleneck is information not being shared clearly or early enough to merchants and even within the team.

Where did the stakeholder give a solution instead of describing a need?

It is not about just building a portal but about refining it into an actual need. A online real time dashboard, reliable onboarding process, and settlement estimates are always visible. Separating the solution from the need helps us design something that actually solves the problem rather than just adding a tool.

What information should the BA investigate further before writing requirements?

Actual baseline metrics, average onboarding duration, enquiry volume broken down by category, and approval rates. These numbers will give us a clear starting point so we can measure whether the solution is making a real difference and not adding to the number of tools.